

Mitsubishi has made an additional investment of Rs 1,495 crore in 2006. Companies such as Asian Petrochemicals, Indian Oil Corporation, Reliance and the Indonesian Salim Group have all come to Haldia, the polymer hub.

Kolkata may have been a late entrant into India's booming retail sector, but it is more than claiming a huge share of the pie right now. A CII report says that the origin of one out of every six shops located in India's top 25 cities can be traced to Kolkata. While Pantaloon's remains one of the biggest success stories for the city, now planning 10 stores in Kolkata itself, more and more international brands are coming in. The city-based RPG Group, which is turning one of its warehouses into one of India's biggest malls (four lakh square feet of space in Beckbagan, the heart of the city), says it has already invested Rs 300 crore of capital in the retail sector, comprising the malls and the Spencer's stores.

Among Kolkatans themselves, the disposable incomes have been on the rise – according to a report by the National Council of Applied Economic Research (NCAER), about 62 per cent of the households in Kolkata had annual incomes of up to Rs 18,000 in 1985-86; while just a decade later, the figure had touched Rs 25,000-77,000 for some 61 per cent of the households. Going by the Census, it also qualifies as the second largest metro market in India, also representing an amalgamation of the advantages of a metro city, and the comparatively modest living costs of a non-metro town. No wonder, a government brochure calls West Bengal the "fastest growing state, with the highest SDP growth and per capita income."

Agriculture being the backbone of the state, a report says that in the next 10 years the total food processing industry in West Bengal will be worth over Rs 15,000 crore. So far, the state has



▲ Chief Minister Buddhadev Bhattacharya with Sanjeev Goenka



▲ Manabendra Mukherjee – MIC : Tourism

received food processing business with companies like Pepsi's Frito Lays, Hindustan Lever, Nestle, Dabur and Marico setting up shop. The state also boasts the country's first hydel power, thermal power and even solar power stations. With 7,616 megawatt generated every year, a Nasscom report has said that the power infrastructure in West Bengal is the best in the country. The state is always in a position to lend power to its neighbouring states. What's more, electricity tariffs in the state are the lowest in the country.

West Bengal, locationally, has always been blessed. Situated on the Ganges, the banks of which have been witness to hundreds of years of colonial history, Kolkata and its nearby towns offer heritage to you fill. From Chandernagore, the French Colony, to the relics of another era at Murshidabad's Imambara and Hajaruari, to the grand colonial structures such as Victoria Memorial, Town Hall and the Indian Museum that dot the cityscape, West Bengal is a tourist's delight. New destinations such as Garhpanchkot and Dooars are being developed, while Darjeeling still remains a huge draw all over the world for the glorious view of the Kanchenjunga that it offers.

The rise in industry has demanded more and more real estate options, and West Bengal has catered to that beautifully. About 20 million square feet of additional built up IT space will be available in West Bengal in the next two years. While IT Parks are being developed in new Town, Salt Lake and Rajarhat, a number of housing projects of international standards, in collaboration with the West Bengal Housing Board, are coming up all over the state. The state still remains one with the lowest cost of living among Indian metros, having a consumer price index of 417 compared to Hyderabad's 486 and Bangalore's 476.

A stable government ensures a stable law and order system, and Kolkata remains relatively safer than other metros. Coupled with that is a vibrant cultural atmosphere, and positive attitude towards industry, and a proud 30-year-old government, and West Bengal is all poised to be a leader of the future.



▲ Jyoti Basu



▲ Dr. Debesh Das – Minister – IT